**SONIC EXPERIMENTERS**
(clockwise from far left) Arjun Vagale (AsymetriK): Kartik Pillai (JAMBLU); and Ruhail Qaisar (SISTER)

sound they are known for. But once you break the mould, you allow yourself the freedom to express yourself, regardless of genre. AsymetriK is my playground for such experiments."

Vagale, like Pillai, has a musical day job to pay the bills. Other experimental artistes have been able to shape their adventures into more accessible tunes, like Lifafa's honing of his early freewheeling soundscapes into commercially viable avant-pop. But for artistes like Leh's Ruhail Qaisar—who fronts SISTER and has an album out on Berlin's Danse Noire label this October—it's difficult to find financial sustainability. Far from dreaming of stardom, Qaisar is just hoping to build enough of an international audience to play the occasional European tour and do a day job alongside. "The industry in India is run by this gate-keeping network; there's no money for experimental music," says Qaisar. "But I don't want to compromise on my music."

That uncompromising stance runs through the current wave of left-field soundsmiths. Perhaps that's necessary when you make music so abrasive that it can empty the room in seconds (as in the first time Jessop&Co played Mumbai), or so gut-wrenching that you leave with an emotional concussion (Disco Puppet). It's not that the international experimental scene is a route to stardom. But in India, making experimental music can often seem akin to screaming into the void. JAMBLU, for example, has released three records since 2019, and received barely any review or acknowledgement from the Indian music press.

"That made me look deeper inside and ask why I'm doing this in the first place," says Pillai. "Because this is not mainstream music, and I can make mainstream music. I'm not doing it because I have a vision for what I like music to be, and that's deeply personal. If somebody connects with it, I'm finding that more and more special." He concludes ruefully, "I don't know what exactly is keeping me going. But I know I want to keep doing it." ■

**–Bhanuj Kappal**



# The Right Noises

*A left-field Indian electronica playlist for the uninitiated*

### ➜ JINRAJ JOSHIPURA
**Space Liner 2001 (Excerpt)**

Only a three-and-a-half-minute extract of this 30-minute tribute to *Kubrick's 2001: A Space Odyssey* is available online. Recorded in 1970 by a 19-year-old NID student, it's an attempt to imagine sound as outside of history and musical tradition.

### ➜ CHARANJIT SINGH
**Raga Todi**

Taken from the composer's long-forgotten but now iconic 1984 album *Ten Ragas to A Disco Beat*, this attempt to translate the ragas to synthesisers would end up prefiguring some of the most recognisable sounds of electronic dance music.



### ➜ Teddy Boy Kill - Tonic

Teddy Boy Kill's truly wild live sets were never properly captured on record, but their blend of glitch, hip-hop, alternative music and synth explorations made for a wildly eclectic mix. Turn on, tune in, weird out.

### ➜ Hemant S.K.
**Techie Commits Suicide**

A genial, soft-spoken elder of the noise scene, Hemant makes computer-generated noise music that throbs and gyrates with distorted menace. This track is one of the highlights of his 2018 album, *Divided by Zero*, a grimly witty record.



### ➜ Bombay Black - Uncertain

It's hard to pick a single track off the second eponymous album by electro-funk-jazz supergroup Bombay Black, but *Uncertain*'s off-kilter IDM rhythms under eerie snatches of jazz piano and funk bass were at the cutting-edge of 2002 electronica.

### ➜ JAMBLU
**Gone Swimming**

The title track of JAMBLU's 2019 album, this track showcases the artiste's diverse range—lo-fi tape hiss meets glitchy synths meets confessional R&B. It's a masterclass in making a pop song from wildly divergent ingredients.



### ➜ Disco Puppet - HAOAH

Bengaluru's Shoumik Biswas has moved to a more intimate, guitar-led sound on his latest album, but this playful track from 2017's *Princess This* exemplifies his genre-bending approach to composition. Redlining bass pulses with martial precision, and synths skitter like knives on a kitchen sink.

### ➜ The Earth Below / SISTER - Drenched

Though Ruhail Qaisar specialises in extreme noise and dark lo-fi ambient music, he uses his noise-making abilities for The Earth Below's cinematic, post-apocalyptic soundscape on this collaboration. It's a great track, buoyed by the give-and-take between two experimental artistes.